

JSS 2 NIGERIAN HISTORY – FIRST TERM

TOPIC 5: NIGERIAN CIVIL WAR I – CAUSES (1967–1970)

1. Background

The Nigerian Civil War (also called the Biafran War) lasted from July 1967 to January 1970. It was fought between the Federal Military Government and the secessionist Republic of Biafra (mainly the former Eastern Region).

2. Main Causes

- **Ethnic and regional tensions** – deepened by the 1966 coups and the killing of politicians and officers from particular regions.
- **Pogroms and mass displacement** – attacks on people of Eastern origin in the North in 1966 led many to flee to the East; trust in the federation collapsed for many Easterners.
- **Failure of political agreements** – the Aburi Accord (January 1967) between Gowon and Ojukwu was interpreted differently by both sides and was not fully implemented.
- **Creation of twelve states** – in May 1967 Gowon divided the country into twelve states, which the Eastern leadership saw as an attempt to weaken the East (especially its control of oil).
- **Declaration of Biafra** – on 30 May 1967, Colonel Odumegwu Ojukwu declared the independent Republic of Biafra; the Federal Government rejected secession and prepared to use force to keep the country united.

3. Summary

The Civil War resulted from a chain of political crises, coups, ethnic violence, failed negotiations and the decision of the Eastern Region to secede. The federal side fought to preserve the unity of Nigeria.

End of Topic 5